

To the Bahá'ís of the World

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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Rid.ván 2012

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Dearly loved Friends,

21.1 Midafternoon on the eleventh day of the Rid .ván festival

one hundred years ago, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, standing before an audience several hundred strong, lifted a workman’s axe and pierced

the turf covering the Temple site at Grosse Pointe, north of

Chicago. Those invited to break the ground with Him on

that spring day came from diverse backgrounds—Norwegian, Indian, French, Japanese, Persian, indigenous American, to

name but a few. It was as if the House of Worship, yet unbuilt,

was fulfilling the wishes of the Master, expressed on the eve of the ceremony, for every such edifice: “that humanity might find

a place of meeting” and “that the proclamation of the oneness

of mankind shall go forth from its open courts of holiness.”

21.2 His listeners on that occasion, and all who heard Him in

the course of His travels to Egypt and the West, must have but

dimly comprehended the far-reaching implications of His words

for society, for its values and preoccupations. Still today, can

anyone claim to have glimpsed anything but an intimation, dis-

tant and indistinct, of the future society to which the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh is destined to give rise? For let none suppose

that the civilization towards which the divine teachings impel

humankind will follow merely from adjustments to the present order. Far from it. In a talk delivered some days after He laid

the cornerstone of the Mother Temple of the West, 'Abdu'l-Bahá

stated that "among the results of the manifestation of spiritual

forces will be that the human world will adapt itself to a new

social form," that "the justice of God will become manifest throughout human affairs." These, and countless other utter -

ances of the Master to which the Bahá'í community is turning time and again in this centennial period, raise awareness of the

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONdistance that separates society as it is now arranged from the

stupendous vision His Father gifted to the world.

21.3 Alas, notwithstanding the laudable efforts, in every land, of

well-intentioned individuals working to improve circumstances

in society, the obstacles preventing the realization of such

a vision seem insurmountable to many. Their hopes founder on erroneous assumptions about human nature that so permeate

the structures and traditions of much of present-day living as to

have attained the status of established fact. These assumptions appear to make no allowance for the extraordinary reservoir

of spiritual potential available to any illumined soul who

draws upon it; instead, they rely for justification on humanity's

failings, examples of which daily reinforce a common sense

of despair. A layered veil of false premises thus obscures a fundamental truth: The state of the world reflects a distortion

of the human spirit, not its essential nature. The purpose of

every Manifestation of God is to effect a transformation in both the inner life and external conditions of humanity. And this

transformation naturally occurs as a growing body of people,

united by the divine precepts, collectively seeks to develop

spiritual capacities to contribute to a process of societal change.

Akin to the hard earth struck by the Master a century ago, the prevailing theories of the age may, at first, seem impervious to

alteration, but they will undoubtedly fade away, and through

the “vernal showers of the bounty of God,” the “flowers of true understanding” will spring up fresh and fair.

21.4 We yield thanks to God that, through the potency of His

Word, you—the community of His Greatest Name—are culti-

vating environments wherein true understanding can blossom.

Even those enduring imprisonment for the Faith are, by their

untold sacrifice and steadfastness, enabling the “hyacinths

of knowledge and wisdom” to flower in sympathetic hearts. Across the globe, eager souls are being engaged in the work of

constructing a new world through the systematic implemen-

tation of the provisions of the Five Year Plan. So well have its features been grasped that we feel no need to comment further

on them here. Our supplications, offered at the Threshold

of an All-Bountiful Providence, are for the assistance of the

Supreme Concourse to be vouchsafed to every one of you in

contributing to the progress of the Plan. Our fervent desire, bolstered by witnessing your consecrated efforts during the past

year, is that you will intensify your sure-footed application of

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not the time to hold back; too many remain unaware of the new

dawn. Who but you can convey the divine message? “By God,”

Bahá'u'lláh, referring to the Cause, affirms, “this is the arena

of insight and detachment, of vision and upliftment, where

none may spur on their chargers save the valiant horsemen of the Merciful, who have severed all attachment to the world of

being.”

21.5 To observe the Bahá'í world at work is to behold a vista

bright indeed. In the life of the individual believer who desires, above all, to invite others into communion with the Creator

and to render service to humanity can be found signs of the

spiritual transformation intended for every soul by the Lord

of the Age. In the spirit animating the activities of any Bahá'í community dedicated to enhancing the capacity of its members

young and old, as well as of its friends and collaborators, to

serve the common weal can be perceived an indication of how a society founded upon divine teachings might develop. And in

those advanced clusters where activity governed by the frame-

work of the Plan is in abundance and the demands of ensuring

coherence amongst lines of action are most pressing, the evolv-

ing administrative structures offer glimmerings, however faint, of how the institutions of the Faith will incrementally come to

assume a fuller range of their responsibilities to promote human

welfare and progress. Clearly, then, the development of the individual, the community, and the institutions holds immense

promise. But beyond this, we note with particular joy how the

relationships binding these three are marked by such tender

affection and mutual support.

21.6 By contrast, relations among the three corresponding actors

in the world at large—the citizen, the body politic, and the institutions of society—reflect the discord that characterizes

humanity's turbulent stage of transition. Unwilling to act as

interdependent parts of an organic whole, they are locked in a

struggle for power which ultimately proves futile. How very different the society which 'Abdu'l-Bahá, in unnumbered Tablets

and talks, depicts—where everyday interactions, as much as the

relations of states, are shaped by consciousness of the oneness of humankind. Relationships imbued with this consciousness

are being cultivated by Bahá'ís and their friends in villages and

neighborhoods across the world; from them can be detected

the pure fragrances of reciprocity and cooperation, of concord

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONand love. Within such unassuming settings, a visible alternative

to society's familiar strife is emerging. So it becomes apparent

that the individual who wishes to exercise self-expression

responsibly participates thoughtfully in consultation devoted

to the common good and spurns the temptation to insist on

personal opinion; a Bahá'í institution, appreciating the need for coordinated action channeled toward fruitful ends, aims

not to control but to nurture and encourage; the community

that is to take charge of its own development recognizes an invaluable asset in the unity afforded through wholehearted

engagement in the plans devised by the institutions. Under the

influence of Bahá'u'lláh's Revelation, the relationships among

these three are being endowed with new warmth, new life;

in aggregate, they constitute a matrix within which a world spiritual civilization, bearing the imprint of divine inspiration,

gradually matures.

21.7 The light of the Revelation is destined to illumine every

sphere of endeavor; in each, the relationships that sustain society are to be recast; in each, the world seeks examples of

how human beings should be to one another. We offer for your

consideration, given its conspicuous part in generating the

ferment in which so many people have recently been embroiled, the economic life of humanity, where injustice is tolerated

with indifference and disproportionate gain is regarded as the

emblem of success. So deeply entrenched are such pernicious attitudes that it is hard to imagine how any one individual can

alone alter the prevailing standards by which the relationships

in this domain are governed. Nevertheless, there are certainly

practices a Bahá'í would eschew, such as dishonesty in one's

transactions or the economic exploitation of others. Faithful adherence to the divine admonitions demands there be no

contradiction between one's economic conduct and one's beliefs

as a Bahá'í. By applying in one's life those principles of the Faith that relate to fairness and equity, a single soul can uphold

a standard far above the low threshold by which the world

measures itself. Humanity is weary for want of a pattern of life

to which to aspire; we look to you to foster communities whose

ways will give hope to the world.

21.8 In our Ridván message of 2001, we indicated that in

countries where the process of entry by troops was sufficiently

well advanced and conditions in national communities were

favorable, we would approve the establishment of Houses of

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a feature of the Fifth Epoch of the Formative Age of the Faith.

With exceeding joy we now announce that national Mashriqu'l-

Adhkárs are to be raised up in two countries: the Democratic

Republic of the Congo and Papua New Guinea. In these, the criteria we set are demonstrably met, and the response of their peoples to the possibilities created by the current series of Plans

has been nothing short of remarkable. With the construction of

the last of the continental temples in Santiago under way, the initiation of projects for building national Houses of Worship

offers yet another gratifying evidence of the penetration of the

Faith of God into the soil of society.

21.9 One more step is possible. The Ma shriqu'l-Adhkár, de -

scribed by 'Abdu'l-Bahá as "one of the most vital institutions

of the world," weds two essential, inseparable aspects of Bahá'í

life: worship and service. The union of these two is also reflected

in the coherence that exists among the community-building

features of the Plan, particularly the burgeoning of a devotional spirit that finds expression in gatherings for prayer and an

educational process that builds capacity for service to humanity.

The correlation of worship and service is especially pronounced in those clusters around the world where Bahá'í communities

have significantly grown in size and vitality, and where en-

gagement in social action is apparent. Some of these have been

designated as sites for the dissemination of learning so as to

nurture the friends' ability to advance the junior youth program in associated regions. The capacity to sustain this program, as

we have recently indicated, also fuels the development of study

circles and children's classes. Thus, beyond its primary purpose, the learning site fortifies the entire scheme of expansion and

consolidation. It is within these clusters that, in the coming

years, the emergence of a local Ma shriqu'l-Adhkár can be

contemplated. Our hearts brimming with thankfulness to the Ancient Beauty, we rejoice to inform you that we are entering into consultations with respective National Spiritual Assemblies

regarding the erection of the first local House of Worship in each of the following clusters: Battambang, Cambodia; Bihar Sharif, India; Matunda Soy, Kenya; Norte del Cauca, Colombia; and Tanna, Vanuatu.

21.10 To support the construction of the two national and five local Mashriqu'l-Adhkárs, we have decided to establish a Temples Fund at the Bahá'í World Centre for the benefit of all

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONsuch projects. The friends everywhere are invited to contribute to it sacrificially, as their means allow.

21.11 Beloved coworkers: The ground broken by the hand of 'Abdu'l-Bahá a hundred years ago is to be broken again in seven more countries, this being but the prelude to the day

when within every city and village, in obedience to the bidding of Bahá'u'lláh, a building is upraised for the worship of the

Lord. From these Dawning-Points of the Remembrance of

God will shine the rays of His light and peal out the anthems of His praise.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]